

AP Chinese Language & Culture: The Complete Exam Guide

The new project-based exam explained: the presentation and Q&A, story narration and email response, listening and reading, and 10 practice questions in Chinese.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



~2 hrs

fully digital exam
in Bluebook

55+4

multiple-choice +
free-response tasks

35%

of your score comes
from your project

85–89%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Your project, plus skills

The exam now centers on a research project you complete during the year about a Chinese-speaking community. Your score (1–5) combines speaking about that project, writing, and listening and reading.

20%

Project presentation

15%

Project Q&A

15%

Story + email

50%

Multiple choice • 55 Q

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
Q1 • Project presentation	20% of score 3 min prep + 3 min speaking	Deliver a spoken presentation in Chinese answering the project prompt, using your Personalized Project Reference (PPR).
Q2 • Project Q&A	15% of score 4 questions • 40 s each	Answer four pre-recorded questions about your project research.
Q3–4 • Story narration + email	7.5% + 7.5% of score 30 minutes total	Story narration: write a story based on a series of pictures. Email response: reply to an email from a friend or community member.
II • Multiple choice	50% of score ~65 min 55 questions	Listening: 25 questions (25 min, 25%) on audio sources • Reading: 30 questions (40 min, 25%) on print texts.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

BEFORE EXAM DAY

Submit your PPR by late April

Your **Personalized Project Reference** is a structured outline of your research and sources. Submit it in the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline; you can see it during the presentation.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION II

02 Listening & reading

55 questions in about 65 minutes. Listening questions use authentic audio such as interviews, podcasts and announcements; reading questions use articles, ads, charts and literary texts.

25

listening questions on audio sources

30

reading questions on print sources

50%

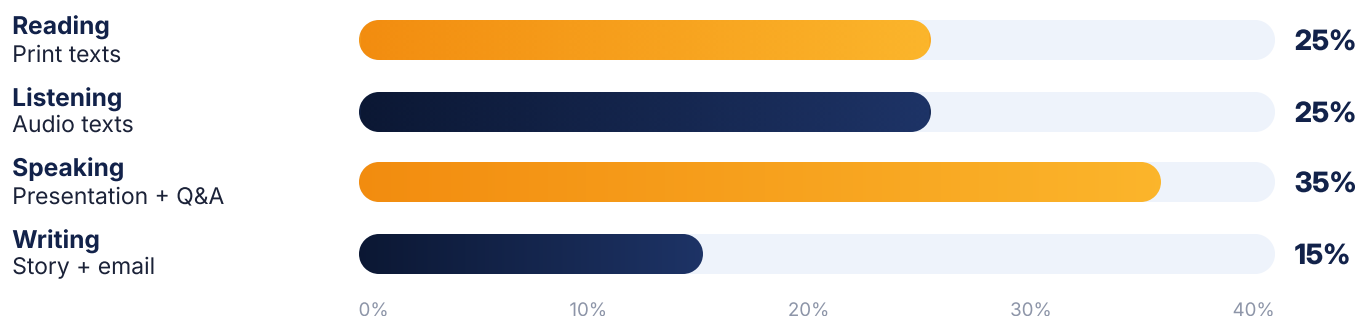
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

◆ How your score is built

Share of the total exam score for each skill.

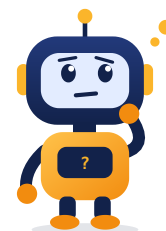


What this means for your study time: Speaking about your project is the single biggest part of the exam (35%). Listening and reading together are half, so daily exposure to authentic audio and texts matters.

◆ Strategies that work on this section

- ◆ **Preview the questions** before each audio plays, so you know what to listen for.
- ◆ **Take short notes** while listening: names, numbers, opinions and the main idea.
- ◆ **Read the introduction line** of each text; it tells you the source and purpose.
- ◆ **Don't translate word for word.** Use context to infer meaning of unknown words.
- ◆ **Watch for paraphrase.** Correct answers rarely repeat the text's exact words.
- ◆ **Never leave a blank.** There is no penalty for guessing.

Listen to **Chinese podcasts or news** for 10 minutes a day. It trains your ear for natural speed.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 6 themes & the project

Course content is organized into six themes. Your project connects research to one of them, using authentic sources in Chinese.

THEME

1

Families & Communities

Explore: family values, traditions and how communities are changing in Chinese-speaking communities.

THEME

2

Language & Culture

Explore: how language, media and technology shape identity and cultural expression.

THEME

3

Art & Creativity

Explore: how art, music and literature reflect a community's history and values.

THEME

4

Science & Technology

Explore: how scientific and technological change affects daily life and society.

THEME

5

Contemporary Life

Explore: education, work, leisure, popular culture and changing lifestyles.

THEME

6

Global Contexts

Explore: how global issues such as the environment, migration and health affect communities.

◆ The course project, step by step

1 • Research

Investigate the project prompt using authentic Chinese-language sources.

2 • Build your PPR

Create your Personalized Project Reference: a structured outline of findings and sources.

3 • Submit

Upload the PPR to the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline.

4 • Present

On exam day, present for 3 minutes and answer 4 questions about your research.

SECTION I

04 The free-response tasks

Two spoken tasks about your project, then two written tasks in 30 minutes.

Presentation 20%

Q&A 15%

Story 7.5%

Email 7.5%

Free response = 50% of your AP score

Q1

Project presentation

3 min prep · 3 min speaking

Answer the project prompt using what you learned. Organize clearly: introduction, main findings with examples from your sources, and a conclusion.

Practice timing: aim for 2:45–3:00 so you use the full time.

Q2

Project Q&A

4 questions · 40 seconds each

Respond to four recorded questions that ask you to explain, extend or reflect on your research.

Answer directly in the first sentence, then add one detail or example.

Q3

Story narration

Written · with Q4 in 30 min

Write a story based on a series of pictures, with a beginning, middle and end.

Use time words and connectors to link the pictures.

Q4

Email response

Written · with Q3 in 30 min

Read an email and write a reply that responds to every question and request in it.

Use an appropriate greeting, register and closing.

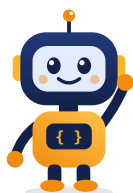
◆ Presentation: your 6 minutes

Review PPR
1 min

Plan points
2 min

Present
3 min

Use the preparation time to choose two or three key findings and an example for each.



Use **linking words** and a range of tenses. Variety in your speaking raises your score.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong presentation

Here is a short sample of a strong project presentation opening, annotated to show what earns points.

PRACTICE TASK · WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (project presentation style): How are young people in a Chinese-speaking community keeping traditional arts alive? Use what you learned in your research. *For the written tasks, you can type with Pinyin (simplified or traditional) or Bopomofo input.*

Sample presentation opening

- ① 今天我想介绍一下北京的年轻人怎么保护传统手工艺。
- ② 根据我读的一篇文章，在一家社区中心，参加剪纸课的学生比五年前多了一倍。
- ③ 另外，很多年轻人说，学习剪纸让他们更了解自己的文化和历史。
- ④ 所以我认为，这些课程说明中国人很重视把传统文化传给下一代。

- ① **Clear introduction** that answers the prompt.
- ② **Specific finding** with an example from a source.
- ③ **Connectors** that organize ideas.
- ④ **Cultural insight** beyond simple facts.

Five habits for every speaking and writing task

1

Answer the question in your first sentence.

2

Use connectors to organize ideas.

3

Vary tenses and sentence structures.

4

Self-correct briefly, then keep going.

5

Use every second of speaking time.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **memorize** your presentation! (Careful.)



01 A memorized script

The presentation should sound natural. Know your findings well rather than reciting word for word.

02 Missing the PPR deadline

Without a submitted Personalized Project Reference, you won't have your outline during the presentation.

03 Too short

Stopping at 1:30 of a 3-minute presentation limits your score. Use the full time.

04 Ignoring the Q&A question

Answer exactly what is asked first; then elaborate.

05 Long silences

Use fillers in Chinese and keep going rather than stopping.

06 Only one tense

Showing past, present and future tenses demonstrates range.

07 Word-for-word translation

Think in phrases, not single words, to avoid unnatural sentences.

08 Wrong register in the email

Match formality to the recipient: a teacher needs polite forms; a friend can be casual.

09 Skipping notes while listening

Brief notes on names, numbers and opinions make audio questions much easier.

10 Cultural facts without insight

Explain what a practice or product shows about a community's perspectives.

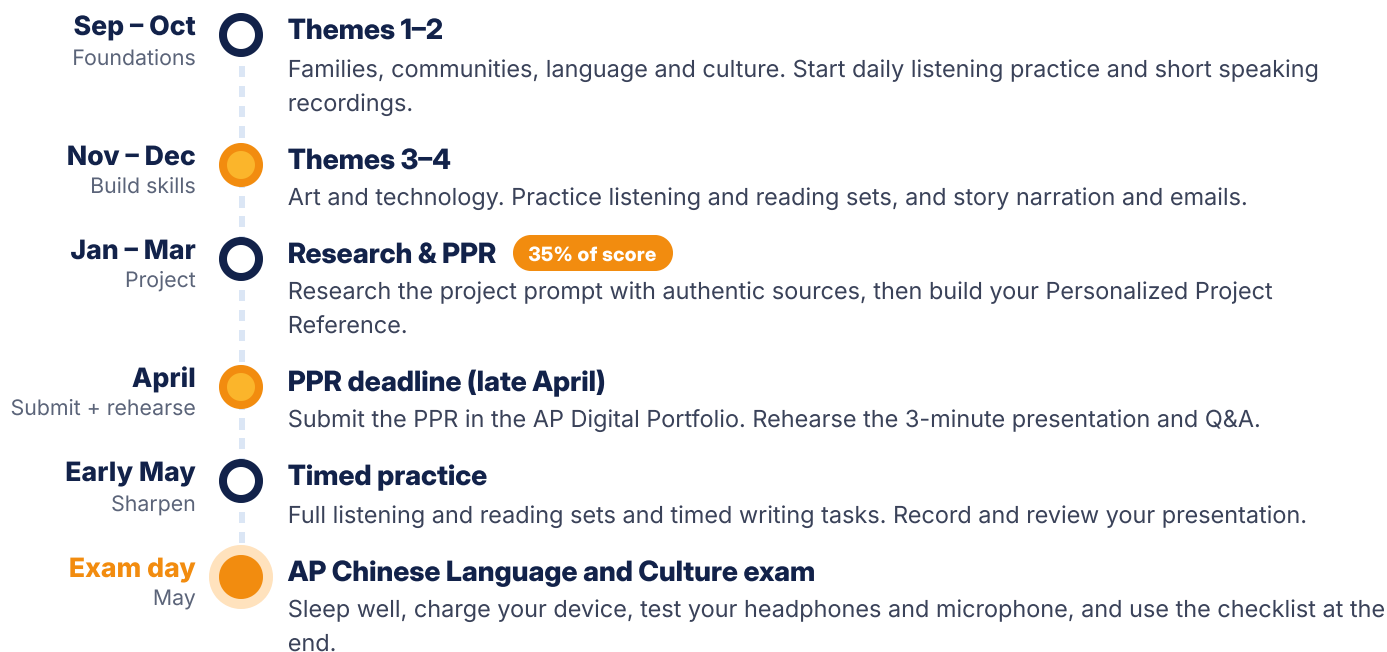
Quick self-check: can you speak about your project topic in Chinese for three minutes, using time words, connectors such as 另外、但是、所以、虽然...但是..., and at least one 比 comparison?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Schedule your project research early so the PPR is ready well before the late-April deadline.



◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one listening and one reading set	Name your weaker skill
3 weeks out	Daily: 10 min listening, one recorded presentation run	Use the full 3 minutes
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish every task
Final week	Light review: PPR, connectors, Q&A practice	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original reading and language questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Explanations on the answer page are in English. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 阅读 · 主要内容

请阅读短文，回答第 1-4 题。

近年来，越来越多的中国年轻人开始学习传统手工艺，比如剪纸和书法。在北京的一家社区中心，每个周末都有免费的剪纸课。“我原来觉得剪纸很难，”十六岁的李明说，“但是学了以后，我发现它能让我更了解自己的文化。”社区中心的王老师已经教了十年。她说，参加课程的学生比五年前多了一倍。

ACT SAT GO 原创练习短文

这篇文章主要讲的是什么？

- A 年轻人学习传统手工艺
- B 北京的交通问题
- C 王老师退休了
- D 剪纸课很贵

2 阅读 · 细节

李明一开始觉得剪纸怎么样？

- A 很容易
- B 很无聊
- C 很贵
- D 很难

3 阅读 · 数据

根据文章，现在参加课程的学生比五年前：

- A 少了一半
- B 多了一倍
- C 一样多
- D 多了十倍

4 词汇

“免费”的意思是：

- A 很贵
- B 很远
- C 不用花钱
- D 很早

5 语法 · 否定

选择正确的词：“我__去过北京。”

- A 没
- B 不
- C 别
- D 很

6 语法 · 连词

“虽然下雨了，__我们还是去上课了。”

- A 因为
- B 所以
- C 但是
- D 如果

7 量词

“我买了两__书。”

- A 个
- B 张
- C 只
- D 本

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

8 语法 · 比较

哪个句子是对的？

- A 今天比昨天很冷。
- B 今天比昨天冷多了。
- C 今天比昨天非常冷。
- D 今天比昨天太冷。

9 电子邮件 · 语体

给老师写电子邮件，哪个开头最合适？

- A 嘿！
- B 哥们儿，
- C 喂，
- D 尊敬的王老师：

10 文化 · 观点

哪个句子最能表达文化观点？

- A 剪纸课在周六上。
- B 很多人认为，学习传统手工艺可以把文化传给下一代。
- C 教室里有二十张桌子。
- D 社区中心在北京。

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A	The text describes young people in Beijing learning traditional crafts such as paper-cutting and calligraphy.
2	D · 很难	Li Ming says "我原来觉得剪纸很难" (at first I thought paper-cutting was hard).
3	B · 多了一倍	Teacher Wang says the number of students has doubled compared with five years ago.
4	C	"免费" means free of charge.
5	A · 没	Past experience with 过 is negated with 没: 我没去过北京.
6	C · 但是	The pattern 虽然...但是... means "although... (but)...".
7	D · 本	本 is the measure word for books.
8	B	In 比 comparisons, adverbs such as 很, 非常 and 太 can't be used; add 多了 or 一点 after the adjective instead.
9	D	尊敬的王老师 is a respectful, formal greeting for a teacher.
10	B	A perspective explains beliefs and values (passing culture to the next generation), not just facts.

9-10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6-8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0-5

Build foundations now. Read and listen to Chinese every day, and practice speaking for three minutes without stopping.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 85–89% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Chinese Language and Culture, and about 48–55% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

85–89%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

48–55%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Your **PPR was submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio before the late-April deadline
- ☐ **Headphones and microphone** tested for the speaking and listening sections
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your PPR and practice the presentation once the night before

In the free-response tasks: answer every prompt directly, organize ideas with connectors, show a range of vocabulary and tenses, use the full time, and explain cultural perspectives, not just facts.



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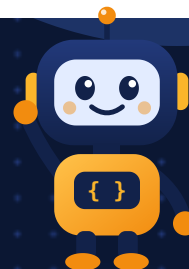
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Chinese plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Chinese conversation practice

Live 1-on-1 speaking sessions to build fluency for the presentation and Q&A.

Project & writing skills

Story narration and email coaching and research-skills support. Your project stays 100% your own work.

Listening & reading practice

Timed sets with authentic audio and texts, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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